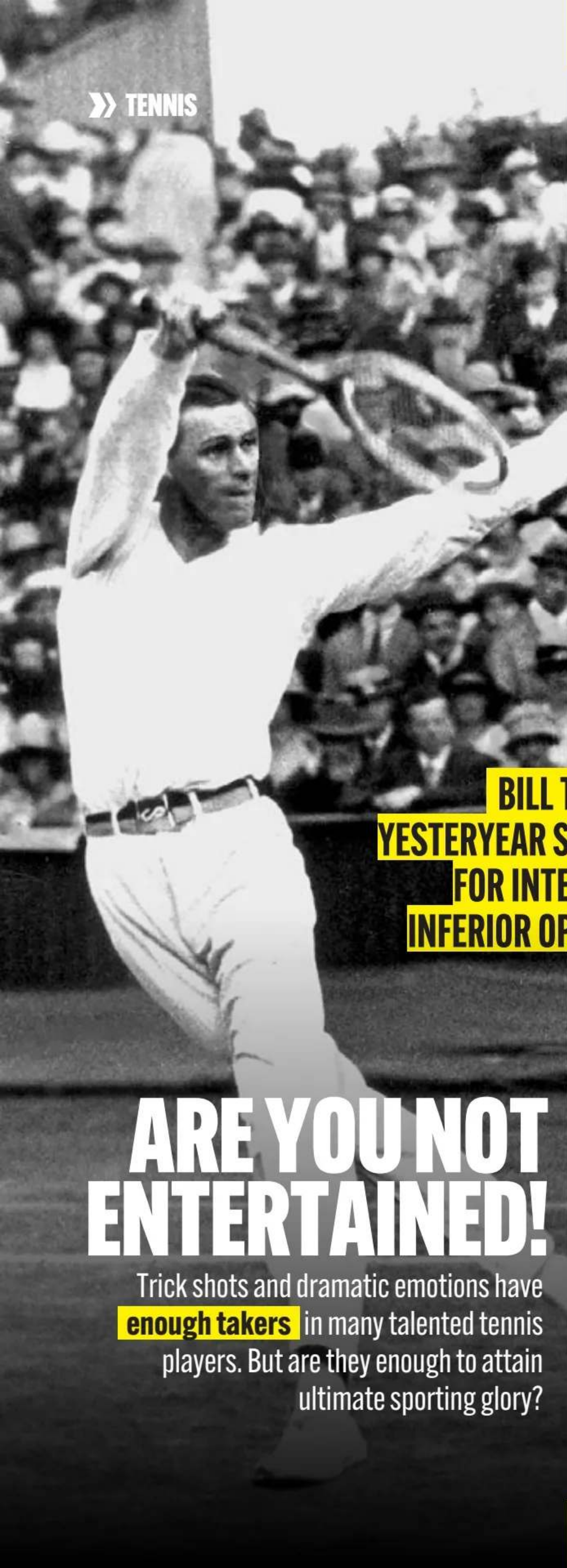




ARE YOU NOT ENTERTAINED!

Trick shots and dramatic emotions have **enough takers** in many talented tennis players. But are they enough to attain ultimate sporting glory?

BILL TILDEN, A LARGER-THAN-LIFE YESTERYEAR SUPERSTAR, WAS RENOWNED FOR INTENTIONALLY FALLING BEHIND INFERIOR OPPONENTS IN EARLY ROUNDS

Paul Fein

"Trick shots are like happiness because they are my moments, it's mine"

— Gael Monfils.

From Bill Tilden and Jimmy Connors to Roger Federer and now Carlos Alcaraz, tennis champions have captivated crowds with their trick shots, creative mimes, and amusing wisecracks. These geniuses abounded in talent, flair, and audacity, and they often flaunted it. These charismatic characters brought drama, controversy, and beauty. The cultural historian Elizabeth Wilson noted in her illuminating book, *Love Game*, that while tennis was similar to art, it had a significant difference. "Like the medieval jousting tournament or the Spanish bullfight, the tennis spectacle was simultaneously art *and* contest," wrote Wilson. "So, whereas when Nureyev danced, he had a free

field on which to display his virtuosity and the beauty of his art, the tennis player was condemned to force his brilliance *against* an opponent. It is from this that tennis (more, I would argue, than other individual sports and certainly more than team sports) derives its tension: the unremitting pull between the art and the fight."

Epitomising both elements, Tilden, a

In a trance: According to the *New York Journal*, Tilden "moved with all the grace and stage presence of a seasoned actor".

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